Formal communications which would be read by the emperor had to be translated into language that was sufficiently reverential and in keeping with his self-styled status as overlord of ‘All Under Heaven’.

The Cholas launched punitive naval operations against the Srivijaya empire in 1025 CE , plundering the royal capital of Palembang. Srivijaya had played an intermediary role in the India–China trade, and the attack against Srivijaya was probably provoked by the latter interfering with this trade since direct Chola–Song trade would have undermined Srivijaya’s commercial interests. One important consequence of Srivijaya’s defeat was that the Tamil merchant guilds became active players in the trade between India and South-East Asia and China and Tamil merchant communities began to settle in several of the port cities in the region, including Guangzhou and Quanzhou. [4]

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During the Song dynasty, the centre of gravity of Chinese political and economic power moved to southern China, and this shift also coincided with the significant expansion of Chinese maritime trade. The ports on the eastern seaboard of the country became major commercial hubs with an outward-oriented merchant class and resident communities of foreign merchants from several countries along the Indian Ocean littoral. If, as mentioned earlier, the Tang dynasty boasted of a cosmopolitanism derived from the caravan trade over Central Asia, Song cosmopolitanism was created by its active participation in long-distance maritime trade. Chinese culture scaled new heights during this era – in poetry, literature, painting and ceramics.

Buddhism remained a major religious and cultural force and several Indian Buddhist monks came to visit during the early part of the Song era before such visits reduced to a trickle. By this time Buddhism had lost its connect with India, and China had consolidated its role as an alternative, perhaps even a superior, Buddhist universe. From being the centre of the Buddhist cosmos, India became its periphery. China could now once again take its place as the Middle Kingdom.